Saying No to Nick

By Bruce Coville

JEREMY: (Pg 45-58) Nick Foster used to be my best friend, and boy, let me tell you, I miss him. It's not like we had a fight or anything. It's just that I died. Well, I didn't just die. The process was pretty painful and horrible – horrible for me but even worse, I think, for Nick. After all, the two of us had been best friends since kindergarten.

INTRODUCTION

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JEREMY: It seems so weird not to be able to talk to him now. I miss him every day. Of course, the fact that ***What Do I miss?*** Is one of the games we play most often here in The Waiting Room doesn't help any.

I don't suppose "The Waiting Room" is the real name for where I am. But it's what most of us call it, since it's been made clear to us that this is just a temporary stop.

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Okay, What do I Miss? Peanut butter. Sumer vacation. Comic books. Eighth grade, believe it or not. My parents. My dog. Nick.

We were in seventh grade when Nick got really interested in religion. Actually, what he got interested in first was Stacy Prendergast and her shining red hair. Since Stacy was all wrapped up in her church's youth group, Nick decided to join it so he could be near her. This meant that I joined too.

The youth group was all right. We did do a lot of praying, which kind of annoyed me at the time. But who knows – it might be one reason I'm here in The Waiting Room and not someplace a lot worse! I was just as happy when Nick decided he wasn't in love with Stacy anymore, and we could drop out. But as it turned out, even though Nick was no longer in love with Stacy, he had fallen in love with God. Which was how we ended up doing the baptism.

Nick had always liked ceremonies – we had buried more animals in his backyard than I could count. Nick always said a few words over the grave. I think that was his favorite part.

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He was good with words – it was one of the things that made it so hard for me to say no when he got an idea. We were lying in my backyard one night last July, looking at the stars when Nick said . . .

NICK: I think we should do a baptism ceremony, Jeremy. It's a way of cleansing ourselves. Starting over.

JEREMY: What do we need a cleansing for?

NICK: *(laughing)* Are you telling me you've led a life without sin?

JEREMY: Don't we need a priest for something like that?

NICK: Nah. Priests just get in the way. They put a layer between you and God.

JEREMY: *(to audience)* I didn't want to admit to Nick that if there really was a God, having a layer between me and him, her, or it didn't seem like such a bad idea.

NICK: We'll do it at my house. We can use the swimming pool. If we're gonna do this, we're gonna do it mountaintop.

JEREMY: *(to audience)* Mountaintop was a Nickism. It meant doing something all out, all the way.

NICK: Total immersion is what it's called. Come over after your folks have left for work tomorrow. We'll have the house to

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ourselves.

JEREMY: *(to audience)* I still wasn't taking this baptism thing all that seriously. But as Nick kept talking, I realized he was dead serious.

NICK: This is going to help us get pure again. It will take us back to our state of original grace.

JEREMY: What are you talking about?

NICK: It's going to wash away our transgressions. And don't tell me you don't have any, Jeremy. I saw you looking at Mary Sue Betts at the mall yesterday. Lust in your heart is a sin in itself. And we never told Mrs. Parker about that window we broke. Come on, Jeremy. This is important.

JEREMY: *(to audience)* So the next day I showed up at Nick's house, ready for the baptism. He had written out the whole ceremony, and I have to admit it was pretty good. He had tucked the script inside a plastic binder sheet, so we could take it into the water with us. *(to Nick)* Are you sure it's not sacrilegious for us to do this? I mean, it's not like we're priests or ministers or anything.

NICK: I don't think God cars about that. Come on, let's get out of our clothes.

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JEREMY: What?

NICK: We've got to be naked to do this. It's like being born. And you don't get born with clothes on. Mountaintop, Jeremy, just like I said. Look, I've got sheets we can wrap around us when we go outside. But once we go into the pool, it's birthday suit city.

JEREMY: *(to audience)* We got undressed and wrapped the sheets around us, then went out to the pool. *(to Nick)* Who goes first?

NICK: Me, because it was my idea. What we do is, I lie back in the water – you'll have to support me with one arm – and you follow the scripts. It will tell you when to lower me into the water.

JEREMY: I held out my right arm, and cradled Nick's head. Then I read aloud what was in the script. When I got to the part that said "It is time for you to be washed free of your sins," I lowered my arm to let his head into the water. He was kind of floating, so I had to push him down to get him completely under. I wasn't sure how long I was supposed to keep him that way, so I held my breath myself, and when it started to get a little uncomfortable, I let him back up.

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NICK: *(gasping for breath, shaking water from his head)* That was great! Okay, now it's your turn.

JEREMY: We switched places. Nick began to speak, though I think he was reciting from memory rather than reading from the script.

NICK: *(formally)* We come to the water to be washed free of our sins, so that we may become as little children again, pure in the eyes of God, closer to the heart of the universe. Do you, Jeremy, come to this of your own free will.

JEREMY: Yes. *(to audience)* I don't think that was a lie, really. I think I could have backed out, even then. But I had never said no to Nick before, and this didn't seem like the time to start.

NICK: Then it is time for you to be washed free of your sins *(pushing Jeremy under)*

JEREMY: *(to audience; speaking calmly in memory)* It wasn't Nick's fault that I panicked. Maybe I was just spooked by all that God stuff. Whatever the reason, I began to thrash and fight to get up. Did Nick try to hold me down? I honestly can't remember. What I do remember is that somehow I got a big mouthful of water and began gasping for breath. I was

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terrified. I felt as if my heart was trying to beat its way out of my chest.

It wasn't Nick's fault. It surely wasn't his fault that I had a weakness in my heart that no one – not me, not my parents, not my doctor – even knew was there. Not his fault that my heart blew a valve. Not his fault that I went limp and died there in the pool, in his arms. Not his fault at all.

Somewhere far behind me I could hear Nick . . .

NICK: *(sobbing)* No! No! Jeremy! Come back! Jeremy!

JEREMY: *(to audience)* But it was too late for that. For once I couldn't do what Nick said. *(beat)* It took me a while to get used to The Waiting Room and then I figured out how to 'Drop In' -- when you go back to the physical world to check on things. A lot of people advised not to do it. They think Dropping In somehow makes it hard to 'Move On'. I was in no hurry to 'Move On'.

I went to see Nick. Only he didn't look like Nick. I could tell he was being turned inside out by guilt. It was sad. The whole reason he had come up with the baptism was to get rid of guilt, and now he had more of it than ever. But after a

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while I figured out that it wasn't only guilt that was eating at him. It was shame.

The whispering was what tipped me off: kids whispering when Nick walked by. Nick had killed me, they were saying – killed me because we were boyfriends. I was so furious and baffled when I heard them that it took me a while to figure out the obvious: Nick had called 911, of course, and when the rescue squad got to his place, they found my naked body. Nick was probably still naked too. The baptism script might have been enough to convince the police of what had ***really*** happened, but it had no power against the mighty tongue of Rumor.

It made me sick. Not out of shame – you start to let go of that here in The Waiting Room – but because I could tell it was making Nick sick too. Even so, I didn't realize he was in danger until the afternoon I 'Dropped In' to check on him and found him standing at the edge of the pool, staring into the blue ripples.

As I watched, he knelt and dipped his hand into the water.

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Then he gripped the edge of the pool and lowered his head. His shoulders began to shake. He stayed that way for a long time. I wanted to talk to him but didn't know how. I had no voice, no body, no way to say, "It's not your fault, Nick. I'm not angry. I forgive you."

I checked on him every day after that, and every day would find him standing at the edge of the pool, staring into the water as if he could still see me there, as if by looking hard enough he could bring me back, make it all go away. I knew it was getting worse. *(watching, sadly, then. . .)*

Nick goes into the house. I follow. He goes to the garage and takes some rope from his father's workbench. Then he picks up a concrete block. I feel sick. I can't watch this. I have to. I follow him back to the pool's edge.

NICK: *(crying)* I'm sorry, Jeremy . . . I'm so sorry.

JEREMY: Slowly, carefully, he ties the rope around his waist. *(shouts)* ***Nick, don't!*** No sound, even though I'm shouting it with every fiber of my being. He stands the concrete block on end, loops the rope through it, ties another knot. Ties it close, ties it tight. He stands, picks up the block, holds it over

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the water. I fling myself at him, crying, ***"No, no, no!"*** And then I'm inside him.

NICK: Jeremy?

JEREMY: I feel the question, feel his shock, feel his fear and astonishment and hope. And I feel one more thing. Nick did love me, and not just as a friend. He loved me and never dared say it, and I died in his arms with him feeling it, and all the rumors that had no truth in reality had a slicing truth in his own heart.

NICK: *(crying)* I'm so sorry. But I'm going to make up for it. I'm going to make up for what I did. *(holds block over the water)*

JEREMY: ***No, no, no, no no!*** *(to audience)* It's like a wrestling match for a while, Nick willing his arms to drop the block into the pool, me fighting him, trying to control his body and all the while thinking, It's all right, Nick. It's all right.

NICK: *(tormented)* It's not!

JEREMY: *(to Nick)* You were my hero. Heroes don't quit.

NICK: I'm so tired, Jeremy. And I hurt so much. And I'm so ashamed. I hate myself.

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JEREMY: I don't hate you. *(to audience)* And then I realize it's not enough, so I give him the harder words, the words I could never have spoken, or even thought, before I died, words it's hard to repeat even now, even though they're true. *(to Nick)* I love you, Nick.

And that stops him. He puts the block down, then collapses next to it, clutching it as if for some comfort, as if he needs something, anything to hold on to. He begins to sob. He's still sobbing when his parents come home. Which is when I leave.

So now I know. You can't fix someone else's broken heart. And you can't take on someone else's guilt. All you can do is love them. *(beat)* I'm going now. Someone – I don't know who -- has called me. My stay in The Waiting Room is over. I suppose I'll never see Nick again. But I'm glad I could be there for him that one last time. Glad I could tell him I loved him, even if it wasn't the way he wanted. Glad I could finally tell him no.

Good-bye, Nick. I love you.

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